

NINA'S VIEW OF YOSHI + MOSHI

Nina Staehli

The first encounter

Yoshi + Moshi appeared in my studio for the first time in 2012. Back then I did not know that they would be writing their own story one day. I did not even know who they were. I knew only that they were there. They were among the first Big Heads, an assemblage of beings that are neither person nor persona, neither mask nor portrait. They were simply there: with their big eyes and open mouths, and an expression as if something had just happened. To this day, I believe that it is precisely in this that their origin lies. Yoshi + Moshi are not marveling at any one thing in particular: they are marveling at the world itself. Long before we have the ability to say words, make judgments or articulate answers, we marvel. Perhaps this is the place where all insights begin. To this day, I find this sense of wonder much more fascinating than any certainty.

A silent language

Yoshi + Moshi do not speak. Not because they wish to be silent. Not because they reject language. Words are simply not part of their existence. They do not need words because they come from another realm. Their universe is made up of gazes, gestures, materials, touch, movement and atmospheres. Silence is not a void: it is the semiotic space they occupy. They are generators of possibilities. At a time when virtually everything is explained, commented and interpreted, I am interested in spaces that remain open: spaces in which meaning is not supplied, but emerges on its own. That is why Yoshi + Moshi do not tell any stories. They create possibilities and viewers become the co-authors of a meaning-making process. This is what underlies their connection to literature. By that I do not mean stories with a beginning and an end - what I mean is a sort of literature that asks more than it answers. Flaubert dreamed of a book that could come into being solely by virtue of its inner force. Beckett brought his characters to the limits of what can be said. Wittgenstein reminded us that, in the place where language ends, thinking does not end. Roland Barthes believed that a work was only complete once a reader read it. These thoughts have been with me for many years as silent companions. Yoshi + Moshi do not explain philosophy or cite literature, but they move within the same liminal spaces: where language ends and experience begins.

Poetic spaces

To me, the poetic is much more than just a characteristic of language. Poetry is not only a literary genre, but a type of perception, a way of being in the world. It starts in a place where wonder is greater than knowledge. Poetry begins in a place where the world becomes mysterious again. Where we do not have to name things immediately. Where we are willing to endure something that eludes our control. Perhaps that is more important today than ever before. We are living in a time in which knowledge appears to be infinitely available. The great promise of knowledge has increasingly shifted from books to artificial intelligence. We often have the impression that machines could be able to understand and find solutions to everything one day. Artificial intelligence is not replacing people: it is shifting skills, knowledge and responsibility. Which is precisely why the analog does not seem to me today to be a nostalgic countermovement but a reminder of something that can never become completely digital: touch, material, texture, time, presence and weight. In other words: the aura of a counterpart. Yoshi + Moshi and their cosmos are an analog creation. Each puppet, sculpture, painting and surface bears the traces of human hands. Small irregularities, points of resistance and coincidences - all the things that cannot be smoothed out completely. This contains a beauty that cannot be totally conveyed.

Undefined worlds

In the past twenty years we have probably seen countless trees on screens, but forgotten how the bark of a tree feels and smells. In that sense, it is not the past that Yoshi + Moshi are reminding us of, but sensory experiences themselves. Their world is made up of puppets, sculptures, videos, performances and paintings. That is no coincidence, either. Children discover the world through play. They create characters, give them voices, make them die and come back to life, and build new worlds. Identities and legends emerge in play. Yoshi + Moshi recreate themselves. They create representations of their own existence and they play with themselves. I am interested in this moment because it is both deeply human and absurd. Play becomes a mirror of our present: a time that is incessantly observing, documenting and reinventing itself. Yoshi + Moshi observe this world with tenderness and subtle irony.

Legends of their own

Over the years Yoshi + Moshi have begun to distance themselves from me. In the beginning, it was me who created them. But now I sometimes feel as though it was them who created me. They developed their own mythology with its own rules and rituals. It is as though I had opened the door at some point and they simply walked out. Today they travel the world as artists, performers and puppeteers. They do not claim to want to become legends - they already embody the legendary. That is why this exhibition is entitled "Become a Legend". The invitation is not directed at Yoshi + Moshi: it is directed at us people. At the heart of this installation is not fame, but perception. It opens up a space for wonder, play and the willingness to trust our own eyes and let ourselves be moved.

Nina Staehli, 2026